



AFRICAN
MONTESSORI
HUB

MONTESSORI EDUCATION IN AFRICA: A CASE STUDY OF ZIMBABWE'S HERITAGE-BASED CURRICULUM

2025 BASELINE REPORT



1.0 INTRODUCTION

Zimbabwe's education system has undergone significant transformations across pre-colonial, colonial, and post-independence eras, each shaped by socio-political and natural disruptions. The colonial period entrenched inequality through dual systems: missionary education for Africans, limited to religious literacy and menial employment, and government education for Europeans, designed to prepare them for participation in the colonial economy. Post-independence reforms sought to redress these imbalances but achieved only incremental change, leaving structural inequities largely intact. Contemporary discourse emphasizes the need for radical transformation, reflected in the Heritage-Based Curriculum Framework for Primary and Secondary Education (2024–2030).

Within this context, the Montessori approach emerges as a timely pedagogical innovation. This study reviews literature on Zimbabwean education, and Montessori Method in African education, Montessori education outside Africa, conducts field research with key stakeholders, and analyses case studies of Montessori schools in Zimbabwe and a couple of African countries. Findings will inform policy recommendations for integrating Montessori principles into Zimbabwe's education system, highlighting their global relevance and local applicability. We now proceed to present the objectives informing this research.



2.0 OBJECTIVES OF THE RESEARCH

In line with the thrust of the African Montessori Hub, the objectives of the research are to:

- Investigate the prevalence and application of Montessori methods in Zimbabwean education relative to broader African contexts;
- Establish the alignment of Montessori education with Zimbabwe's Heritage-Based Curriculum; and
- Recommend the integration of Montessori educational philosophy, approaches and practices in line with the transformative thrust of the Heritage-Based Curriculum and the decolonisation of education in Zimbabwe.



3.0 CONTEXTUAL BACKGROUND

To justify their presence in Zimbabwe protagonists of proselytisation and colonization posed as harbingers of culture and civilization to Africa impelled by a humanitarian impulse. For this interpretation to succeed, the existence of indigenous education had to be denied. Consequently, a number of myths relating to indigenous education had to be fabricated in support of the theory of benevolence.

Ocitti (1994) argues that two myths were particularly prominent and more serious. The first myth created colonists who occupied the land between the Zambezi and the Limpopo was that there was no education in Africa. Indeed, H. J. Baker (quoted by Ocitti, 1994: 14) writes:

The children of this land (Rhodesia) are nonentities. Nothing at all is done for them. They feed, sit about, and sleep and in this manner they grow until the time come for themselves to do something ... They have no nurseries, no tea parties, no birthdays and no instruction from their parents. They are there, and that is all. Their lives are one big nothing (emphasis added).

While the second myth accepted that there was such a thing as indigenous education, this education was presented as of the primitive type that could best be described as “tribal” or “pre-literate” and, therefore, not an education worth to be described as legitimate education. In the final analysis, this education was as good as no education at all (Ocitti, 1994).

According to Ramose (1999), this denial of African education was part of the larger scheme of the denial of African humanity, the being of the African, which manifest in doubt about African rationality. Ramose (1999) further argues that being human necessarily implies rationality. Thus, it is now generally accepted that as rational beings, Africans clearly arranged educational provisions for their children from the earliest age. They had mechanisms to educate their young ones before the introduction of western education by missionaries.

This was the education missionaries and colonial administrators struggled to suppress to create space for Western type of education. Consequently, missionary education was introduced to initiate Africans into the Christian religion and western culture which were often presented as synonymous.

Missionary education as provided to Africans in Zimbabwe was largely for subservience. Missionaries, in bringing western education to Zimbabwe, were understood to be bringing light to the darkness that was Africa, and turning Africans from savagery to civilization (Samkange, 1966) and, in the words of David Livingstone, bringing to an end “the great social evils of African Society” (Sheffield, 1971:7). This thinking continued to buttress the theory of missionaries as benefactors of Africans, as agents whose brief was the development of Africa through the provision of western education. What the views expressed by Livingstone indicate is also that in reality the focus of missionaries was not on educating Africans, but on converting them to Christianity, and thus softening them for colonization. The sole aim of the missionary movement was presented as the evangelisation of Africans,



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the spread of the Christian message and in the process civilizing Africans. Hence, all the missionaries were seen as having been after spreading Christianity for the benefit of Africans as missionaries were “scattering the seeds of civilization” (Majeke, 1986:9). It is critical to note that missionaries often clashed with the colonial government which accused them of providing Africans with an education that made them aware of their rights. But for Rodney (1972), this was the process of the underdevelopment of Africa leading to the negation of African values, knowledge systems and metaphysical beliefs as they buttressed colonialism. These had to be engaged in independent Africa. In Zimbabwe, the struggle for independence culminated in the attainment of freedom from colonialism in 1980. Significant strides were made in the education sector after 1980. These included:

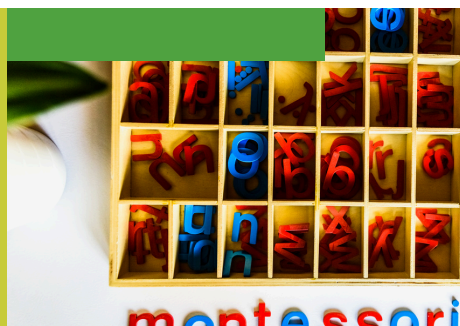
- Quantitative expansion in the provision of education across the education levels, from primary to university level especially between 1980 and 1990;
- Provision of universal free primary education;
- Focus on providing quality education from 1990 onwards;
- Addressing gender and racial imbalances through the provision of equal access policies regardless of race, gender or class;
- Adoption of inclusive education and expansion to persons with disabilities;
- Reform of the curriculum to domesticate education as required by the country's cultural, developmental and political needs through the Curriculum Development Unit then (Madondo, 2015);
- High literacy rates among Zimbabwe with the country being among the best in Africa; and
- Expansion in teacher education to cater for increasing schools and high enrolments.



However, even in post-1980 Zimbabwe, the reforms appear to have been largely cosmetic as missionary educational framework with its Eurocentric orientation remained intact (Maravanyika, 1986; Bhurekeni. 2020). Realising this, Zimbabwe set up the Presidential Commission of Inquiry into Education and Training in 1999 which recommended far reaching changes within the education system. For some reason little traction was gained to implement the recommendation before 2015 by which time it was necessary to establish if the reforms could still be implemented to address challenges with an education system that remained largely colonial in design. After much consultations in 2015 the government developed and introduced the Curriculum Framework for Primary and Secondary Education, 2015 -2022.

The blueprint received mixed reception with some Zimbabweans who thought that the reforms it ushered in were not a big departure from the colonial curriculum while others felt it was too radical especially the introduction of Continuous Assessment Learning Activities (CALA). At higher and tertiary education level an arguably more radical approach was developed which was a big departure in design and orientation from the colonial system. This was in the form of Heritage-Based Education 5.0 which made it mandatory for higher and tertiary education institutions to ensure that their programmes addressed five pillars of development in line with National Vision 2030 that is, Research, Teaching, Community Engagement/Service, Innovation and Industrialisation.

Heritage-Based Education 5.0 made it imperative that higher and tertiary education institutions reorient research so that it spoke to the needs of Zimbabwean society broadly conceived, that teaching be reoriented so that it is informed by research findings and was open to participation by industry, commerce and society; that communities provide the space for research, identifying challenges that needed to be addressed, and participate in teaching and research; and that new programmes developed lead to innovations that resulted in industrialisation leading to the production of innovative entrepreneurs, quality goods and services for the benefit of Zimbabwe as a nation.



Thus, Heritage-Based Education 5.0 is Zimbabwe's Heritage Based Philosophy or Doctrine that formed the bedrock of higher and tertiary education projected to transform Zimbabwe into an Upper Middle Income Economy by 2030. It is an education whose pedagogical drive is to equip graduates with skills that will empower them to be innovative entrepreneurs who see challenges that arise in society as opportunities for transformative development. The graduates adopt a transformative approach as they creatively apply the scientific knowledge generated through cutting edge research, and critical thinking skills acquired through higher and tertiary education to the production of goods and services that meet the needs of society.

Education 5.0 teaches graduates to examine challenges objectively, produce goods and services making use of the local environment and the natural and material resources therein as they participate in national development through the industrialisation of Zimbabwe. The graduates are active in the production of knowledge and technological innovations as they address the real life problems confronting the nation. They contribute to the attainment of the National Development Strategy 1 (NDS1) and Vision 2030.

For Education 5.0 to succeed, it was necessary that higher and tertiary education staff also be transformed from the Education 3.0 philosophy. They had to embrace the new philosophy, be innovative, and develop new approaches to research, teaching and community engagements as they endeavour to produce transformed agents of national development. Thus, Education 5.0 is practical in orientation as it empowers staff and graduates in the higher and tertiary education sector.



3.1 ZIMBABWE'S EDUCATION LANDSCAPE

It was recognised that there was need to harmonise curricula in primary and secondary education with that of higher and tertiary education. The end of the Curriculum Framework for Primary and Secondary Education (2015-2022) provided the needed space and opportunity for the harmonisation of the education system in Zimbabwe.

While the Heritage-Based Curriculum Framework for Primary and Secondary Education (2024-2030) built on the previous curriculum framework, it was by and large informed by the tenets of the higher and tertiary education curricula- the Heritage-Based Education 5.0. The adoption of Heritage –Based Curriculum provides opportunities to take on board other approaches that buttress the use of heritage such as the Montessori approach. Before discussion this particular issue, we review extant literature on education in Zimbabwe in general and the Montessori approach in particular.



3.2 THE HERITAGE-BASED CURRICULUM FRAMEWORK FOR PRIMARY AND SECONDARY EDUCATION 2024-2030

Here we seek to establish the nature of the Heritage- Based Curriculum to figure out how Montessori Method can be of service to Zimbabwe's education system. In the preamble to the Heritage-Based Curriculum Framework for Primary and Secondary Education 2024-2030 the President of the Republic of Zimbabwe stated:

It is my wish that the Ministry will consider introducing more learning areas as per the key sectors and taking on board value addition, beneficiation and refinement with an inclination towards our heritage based thrust ... strengthening the acquisition of vocational and technical skills (MoPSE, 2024:viii) (emphasis added).

The President further reiterates that Vision 2030:

calls for an emancipatory and transformative education system hinged on fostering competences required for school pupils and graduates to participate meaningfully towards the sustainable development of the country (MoPSE, 2024:viii).



He further elaborates that the education system should: ensure that local communities benefit from their own resources through economic solutions, provision of goods and services provided by our pupils. Our pupils will solve their own and community problems using the locally available resources. My government underscores the urgent need for a comprehensive and transformative approach to improve the quality, relevance, and inclusiveness of education through this Heritage Based Curriculum for Primary and Secondary Education 2024-2030. (MoPSE, 2024: viii-ix). (*italics added*).

On his part, in the Foreword to the Heritage Based Curriculum Framework for Primary and Secondary Education 2024-2030 (MoPSE, 2024: x) the Minister of Primary and Secondary Education states:

Education is essential to for human resource development, as it improves human capacity and helps achieve desired goals. It enhances individuals' understanding of their surroundings, their rights, and their ability to improve their own and other people's lives. (*Italics added*)

Critical to the present discussion is when he said:

The curriculum recognises the significance of collaboration of the Ministry with parents, teachers, school administrators, government ministries and agencies, private sector and development partners towards its successful implementation (MoPSE, 2024: X). (*Italics added*)

He further stressed that the HBC seeks to provide “a holistic and transformative education system for the future” (MoPSE, 2024: xi).



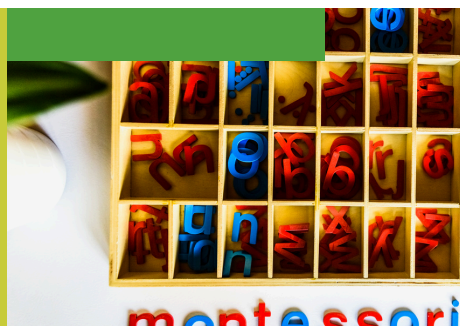
On his part, the Permanent Secretary for Primary and Secondary Education says that “The Curriculum Framework is designed for production of a Zimbabwean primary and secondary learner who is ‘fit for purpose’” (MoPSE, 2024:xii). It provides a “comprehensive and culturally rich education” fostering a “holistic approach to education” (MoPSE, 2024: xii-xiii). More critically, he says it provides for “the use of innovative teaching methodologies ... teaching strategies that cater for diverse learning styles” (ibid). He further says the graduate of this system should be learners “who are proud of their heritage and equipped with appropriate competences to shape a prosperous future for themselves and our nation” (ibid: xiii).

The HBC states the aims as “to produce pupils with relevant competencies such as skills, knowledge, values, attitudes and dispositions that are key to national development” (MoPSE, 2024:3).

The philosophical basis of the HBC is Ubuntu/ Unhu/ Vumunhu. Ubuntu emphasises interdependence, mutual support, and ownership of natural resources, respect for human life, self-respect, and respect for others, the environment and other people’s property. Based on Ubuntu, the HBC’s “fundamental purpose is to provide a structure around which schools can build educational programmes that ensure pupils achieve desired learning outcomes” (MoPSE, 2024:3). These includes the imparting of 21st century skills (MoPSE, 2024:3).

The HBC focuses on:

an educational approach that centres on the heritage and experiences of a country. Its goal is to provide pupils with a curriculum that is reflective of and relevant to their own backgrounds, identities and the country’s resources thereby creating an educational experience that is more inclusive, representative, and meaningful for pupils from that heritage background. It can lead to increased engagement, better academic outcomes and stronger connection between school and community (MoPSE, 2024:4).



Very close to the Montessori focus, HBC is focused on transforming society. It is stated that “the curriculum should respond to dynamic social, political, economic, cultural, religious, legal and technological advancement of a society” (MoPSE, 2024:7).

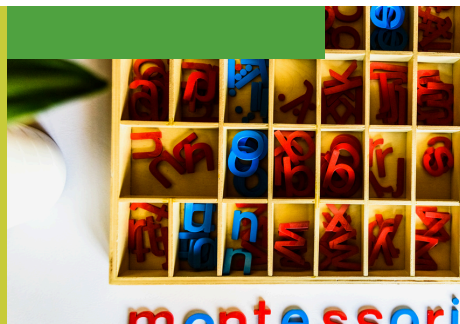
In line with transformation the HBC recognised among many pedagogical shifts:

- The teacher being a facilitator, collaborator, co-learner, co-explorer than a knowledge transmitter;
- Emphasising the analysis, synthesis, evaluation, application of knowledge in pupil's learning;
- Significant broadening of the range of domains leading to the achievement of targeted competences; and
- Use of both formative and summative assessments to check on achievements in respect to cognitive, psychomotor and affective domains.

In terms of skills aligned to the 21st century skills emphasised by the HBC are:

- critical thinking and problem-solving;
- collaboration and leading with influence;
- agility and adaptability;
- research and data analysis;
- taking initiative and being enterprising;
- effective oral and written communication skills; and
- capability to access and analyse information (MoPSE, 2024:8).

The HBC is inclusive in its approach ensuring that learners with disabilities are catered for and that none is left behind. Reflection on the foregoing shows that there is common ground between the Heritage-Based Curriculum and the Montessori Method as will become clear after a discussion of Montessori Method.



4.0 MONTESSORI EDUCATION AT THE INTERNATIONAL LEVEL

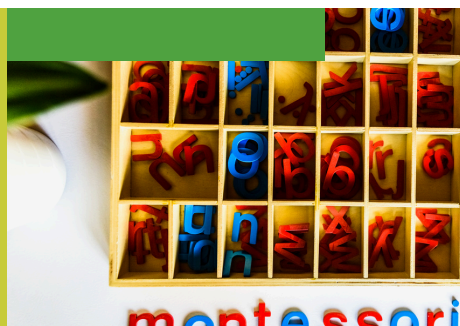
Maria Montessori, being the first woman physician trained at the University of Rome Medical School who entered the field of education working with intellectually impaired children studying them and observing that they could learn many things that appeared impossible (Woods, 2021), deliberately enrolled into the study of philosophy to sharpen her understanding of pedagogy as she worked at the Casa Dei Bambini Children's house. She was able to develop ideas that contributed to metaphysics, epistemology, freedom and morality. Her engagement in philosophy saw her developing ideas in metaphysics where she emphasised interpreting the world through life and stressed in pedagogy an appreciation of children's living individually. Frierson (2023: 38) argues that Montessori's metaphysics involves "two essential elements: teleology and interconnection". According to the former the work of living entities gravitate towards 'a definite purpose'. This entails that attention to goal –directedness should inform those working with learners to fulfil their specific purpose. Frierson argues that because the child is teleologically ordered, pedagogy should respect life's teleology. Hence:

Education must be ... active help given to the normal expansion of the life of the child. The ... body which grows and ... soul which develops ... have one eternal font, life itself. We must neither mar nor stifle the mysterious powers which lie within these two forms of growth (Montessori quoted by Frierson, 2023:39).

Montessori's metaphysics led to her advocacy for purposeful work for children in pedagogical practice. Montessori was alive to the interconnectedness of life. She observed that children had keen interest to observe and understand the world through comprehending the connectedness of all entities. Hence, the need to consider "the cosmic function of each living being ... working in collaboration for the fulfilment of the purpose of Life" (qtd Frierson, 2023: 39). Thus, in terms of her metaphysical orientation, natural teleology and interconnection permeate human life and the universe as a whole including the area of pedagogy. Thus, she argues that the lives of young children provide evidence of teleological orientation of living entities.

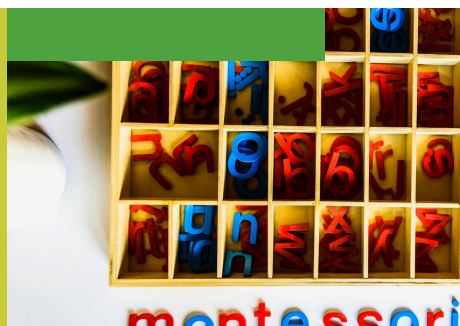
Within the area of epistemology, Montessori was an agential empiricist viewing knowledge as grounded in the senses. Indeed, she argues that "there can be neither ideas nor imagination, nor intellectual construction, if we do not presuppose an activity of the senses" (qtd Frierson, 2023: 40). The senses as active capacities need to be developed in line with the level of development of the learners. The senses have to be developed through making materials designed to cultivate, refine and order children's senses available. "Her focus on agency compels educators to create schools filled with materials to attract and hold student interest" (Frierson, 2023:40). In her philosophy Montessori also stresses the importance of freedom which she argues "should be the basis of pedagogy" (2013. 74). This freedom must be available from birth.

Arguing that freedom is not the absence of discipline she says it is characterised by "absolute obedience to laws of creation that bring about harmony and discipline ... should have as its limit the interests of the group to which [one] belongs ... should be oriented towards work" and characterised by the exercise of choice by both children and adults (Frierson 2023, 41). She makes reference to freedom from constraints and the creation of enabling environments for learners to flourish. That freedom should include respecting others and orientation towards community-oriented work (Frierson, 2023; 41). Montessori also developed a moral philosophy that informed her pedagogical ideas.



Frierson, (2023:42) argues that in her moral philosophy Montessori stressed the importance of 'a good, healthy, or flourishing human life and locates this flourishing in three main values (pillars): character, respect, and solidarity". Her view of morality builds on her explication of freedom. She argues that freedom leads to normalisation by which she means, according to Frierson (2023:42), "the restoration of a person's authentic selfhood, free of repressions and psychological disruptions that come from being inhibited in the exercise of one's life". Character was the ultimate expression of life which requires preservation. It is what guides human behaviour and expression of values. Those with a well-developed sense of character are self-directed and work for the edification of society. "To have character in this sense is to engage with the world in which one lives in a self-directed and excellence-oriented way" (Frierson, 2023: 42).

With regards to the second pillar of her moral philosophy, respect for others is closely linked to character. Character results in respect for others' work as well as consideration for their rights. The third pillar is the value of social solidarity and cohesion transcending mere respect. It entails organic unity, togetherness. Pedagogy should develop these values or pillars.



5.0 POST COVID-19 EDUCATION POLICIES

Zimbabwe like all other countries on the globe was deeply affected by Covid 19 lockdowns. Its education sector had to devise creative and innovative ways to ensure that its school going age was not completely lost in terms of the educational processes. The government therefore developed policies and strategies that ensured continuity of learning while also expanding access to education and strengthening resilience in the education sector. Strategies taken included adopting blended learning approaches (digital, radio, television, print, online), mounting catch up programmes to recover time lost during lockdowns (ZIMTA, 2021), increasing budgetary allocations and targeted support for vulnerable learners such as orphans and children from economically disadvantaged families. Furthermore government provided guidelines for coordinated responses during the crisis (ZIMTA, 2021).

Through the education sector strategic plan 2021 – 2025 government undertook to increase the budget from 13.6% to 15% by 2025 (Adam, et. al, 2022). The government also committed itself to universal enrolment especially at primary school level while reducing dropout rates working with partners such as UNICEF.



. Efforts in increase rural electrification were made to facilitate digital learning. Other interventions to mitigate COVID 19 effects included collaboration with partners to;

- provide the School Improvement Grant;
- roll out alternative learning approaches for example the Learning Passport;
- increasing the roll out of the Basic Education Assistance Module (BEAM); and
- The Harmonised Social Cash Transfer (HSCT) to venerable households (Parliamentary Portfolio Committees on Primary and Secondary Education, 2021).



6.0 FUNDING AND RESOURCE ALLOCATION

From the attainment of independence in 1980 funding and resource allocation in the education sector has always been a challenge. Significant to note is that government prioritise education as a cornerstone for national development and consistently allocated a significant portion of the national budget to education, but this allocation has not been able to be in line with regional and international benchmarks. In 2018 education received 15.8% of the national budget. This was below the 22% benchmark stipulated by the Southern African Development Community (SADC) and the 20% set by the Dakar Framework for Action (UNESCO 2024). A large portion of funding and resources is directed towards wages for staff in the education sector. This leave very little for infrastructure development, teaching materials and innovation. However early childhood development (ECD) received 26.7% of the education sector budget in 2018.

This demonstrate government realisation of the importance of funding foundational learning (UNICEF 2024). Government has benefited from donor support and community initiatives to plug the funding and resource gaps, but this has not able to eradicate inequalities. In 2023 education was allocated 14% of the total budget expenditure which was a decline in educational funding by government.



Fight Inequality Alliance (2023) notes;

Some rural schools do not have proper classroom blocks to shelter the children as they undertake their studies. All this shows unequal access to educational resources and infrastructure in Zimbabwe, especially the twin rural and urban areas in Zimbabwe. Access to a good education system is skewed towards the urban schools making it difficult to put the rural and urban scholars at par which even affects their access to better opportunities in the future.

Efforts to address funding and resource constraints have been in the form of:

- Securing funding from development partners
- Harnessing community based efforts
- Working with teacher parents associations and
- Various fund raising initiatives.



7.0 EMPHASIS ON INNOVATION AND EQUITY

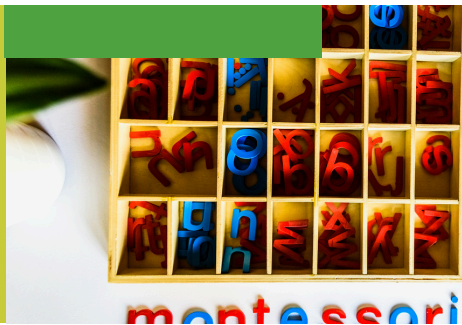
The government realised that research products in schools and universities were not being developed into goods and services. Innovations were not being harnessed. To develop culture of harnessing knowledge products in schools and universities the government of Zimbabwe created the Education, Innovation, Research and Development Centre Act 2021. This was intended to provide a framework for the integration of research innovation and industrialisation into education. The aim was to ensure that innovations and knowledge developed in schools and universities can be harnessed in the creation of jobs and industries in leading to economic development.

Thus the act in other related policies link education to industrialisation and national development. In terms of equity government has embedded inclusive reforms in the 2022 to 2026 Partnership Compact whose thrust is on equitable access, gender equality in support for vulnerable learners. While such efforts are noble in equity and inequality still need to be addressed gaps have persisted within the education sector.



8.0 OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES

- The Heritage Based Curriculum provides for new and innovative approaches to strengthen and widen the provision of primary and secondary education in Zimbabwe.
- There are access gaps within primary and secondary education sector in Zimbabwe
- From the mapping it shows that there are very Montessori School in Zimbabwe.
- The Montessori approach provides an opportunity to improve the quality of education provided at the primary school level in Zimbabwe.



9.0 MONTESSORI EDUCATION IN ZIMBABWE

It is important to be clear from the outset that there is a dearth in literature on Montessori Education in Zimbabwe, let alone scholarly literature. An internet search did not yield much. Literary, there are two or three journal articles that discuss the Montessori Method in Zimbabwe. One is therefore to be content with what is written on the websites of some of the schools and blogs by Zimbabweans and others who have found it important to write on the subject.

This lack of literature on Montessori Education in Zimbabwe has made the Mapping of Montessori presence in Zimbabwe a rather difficult and complex undertaking.



9.1 MAPPING MONTESSORI PRESENCE

There are a number of early childhood development centres, pre-schools and school that identify themselves as Montessori schools offering Montessori education. To avoid discussing each school and what it offers, a diagrammatic representation is presented in **Table 1**.

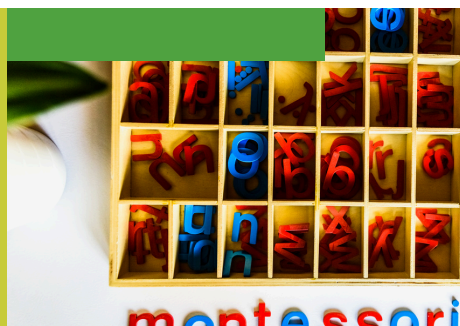
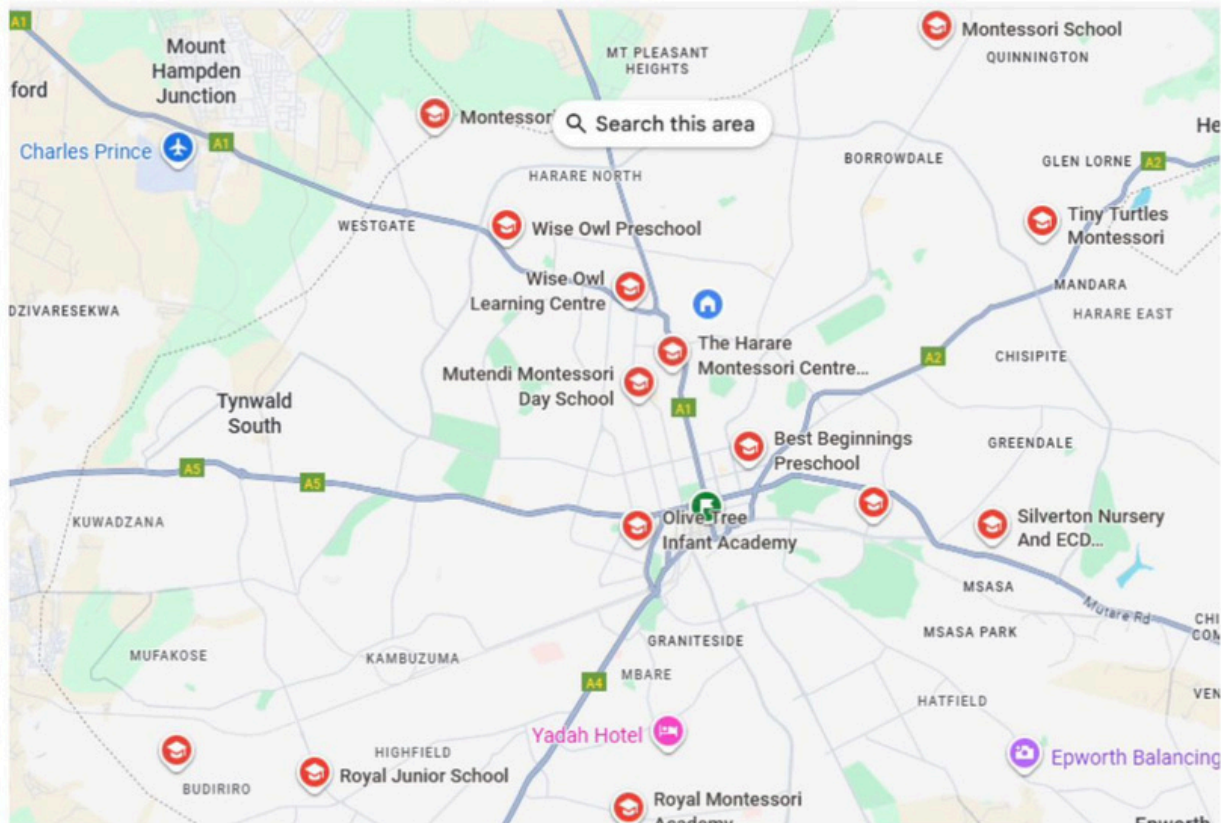
Table 1: Montessori institutions in Zimbabwe

	Name of School	Location	Level				
			Crèche	EDC	Primary	Secondary	Teacher Education
1.	Angels of Grace Early Learning Centre	Mutare	√	√			
2.	Ayne's Montessori School	Harare	√	√			
3.	Bongai Shamwari Early Childhood Centre and Junior School	Mutare	√	√			
4.	Greystone Montessori School	Bulawayo	√				
5.	Harare Montessori Centre and Infant School	Harare	√				
6.	Glen Heritage Montessori School	Harare	√				
7.	Khaya Montessori	Bulawayo	√	√			
8.	Jabulani Montessori Nursery School	Bulawayo	√	√			√
9.	Jacaranda Montessori	Victoria Falls		√	√		
10.	Joyful Montessori	Harare					
11.	Little Bees Montessori Pre-school	Zvishavane	√	√	√		
12.	Little James Montessori	Harare					
13.	Madam Boss Montessori						
14.	Montessori Zimbabwe Primary School	Bulawayo					√
15.	Mutendi Montessori Day School	Harare	√	√	√	√	√
16.	Nyanga Troutbeck School	Nyanga	√	√	√	√	
17.	Royal Montessori Primary School	Harare					
18.	Ruvimbiko Montessori Pre-School	Harare	√	√			
19.	Samantha's Montessori Pre – School	Harare					
20.	Scribbles Montessori	Bulawayo					
21.	Sunshine and Smiles Montessori Pre-school	Harare	√	√			
22.	Tunyenyedzi Montessori School	Harare	√	√			

Map showing distribution of schools across Zimbabwe

Map showing distribution of schools across Zimbabwe

Figure 1. Montessori schools Map



9.2 ADOPTION OF MONTESSORI PRACTICES

From the Map in Figure 1 preliminary findings indicate that the adoption of the Montessori Method with concomitant principles and practices in Zimbabwe is in its infancy and uneven with more schools in Harare and Bulawayo. Some schools are coming up in smaller cities like Gweru, Masvingo and Mutare. Most of the Montessori schools are ECD and junior primary. Most of these schools are in urban areas. A few of these institutions offer teacher education programmes as will be explained later.



10.0 RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

10.1 RESEARCH DESIGN

The study adopts a qualitative methodology to produce rich, nuanced data that facilitates a comprehensive understanding of the relationship between the Montessori Method and the Heritage-Based Curriculum (Patton, 2015). In accordance with the approaches outlined by Yin (2018) and Mouton (2022), data were collected through semi-structured interviews, complemented by systematic observations. The decision to utilize interviews was informed by their capacity to yield in-depth insights into individual experiences and motivations, as emphasized by Yin and Mouton. Consequently, carefully designed interview schedules and observation guides were developed to ensure that critical themes were addressed while allowing for flexibility in participant responses.

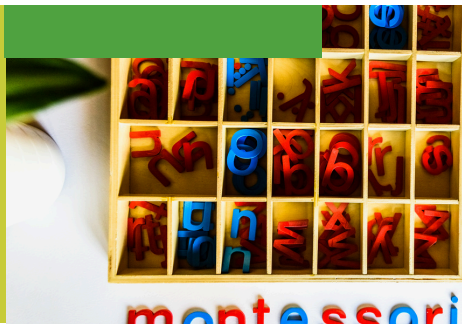
This qualitative approach not only highlights the lived experiences of teachers, parents, and administrators involved in Montessori education but also provides a platform for exploring the complexities of integrating Montessori principles and approaches into heritage-based frameworks. By leveraging both interviews and observations, the study aimed to triangulate data, enhancing the reliability of the findings and fostering a holistic understanding of how these educational paradigms interact. This methodology is particularly valuable in uncovering the diverse perspectives and contextual factors that influence the effectiveness of educational practices in Zimbabwe, ultimately contributing to ongoing discussions about culturally responsive teaching and inclusive educational strategies.



10.2 SAMPLING PARTICIPANTS

The study centred on participants engaged in delivering Montessori education in Zimbabwe. Employing purposive sampling—a non-probability approach—participants were deliberately chosen based on their substantial and relevant expertise concerning the phenomenon under investigation (Patton, 2015). In Zimbabwe, Montessori schools predominantly operate as private institutions, encompassing a spectrum that ranges from elite establishments to those that are less affluent.

Consequently, the participants included teachers, school administrators or heads, parents, and policymakers. In this research, the researchers purposefully selected two teachers, one parent, and one administrator or principal from each Montessori school visited, ensuring a diverse array of perspectives.



10.3 DATA COLLECTION

Data collection for this study was conducted using a combination of interview guides, observational methods, and focus group discussions. The researchers engaged with a diverse array of participants, including teachers, school administrators, parents, and policymakers from various Montessori institutions. This multifaceted approach allowed for a comprehensive exploration of the perspectives and experiences of stakeholders involved in Montessori education. By capturing a wide array of viewpoints, the researchers aimed to provide a nuanced understanding of the implementation and effectiveness of Montessori practices within the context of Zimbabwe's educational landscape. In addition to interviews, unstructured observations were an integral component of the data collection process. These observations, while supplementary, enabled researchers to assess the physical arrangements and overall learning environments of the classrooms, ensuring alignment with Montessori principles.

Through direct observation, the researchers gained valuable insights into several critical areas, including the accessibility of infrastructure, classroom dynamics related to gender and inclusivity, and the instructional methods employed by educators. As noted by Bless et al. (2013), observational data can enrich the qualitative research process by revealing aspects of the educational environment that may not be articulated by participants. This holistic view ensures a more grounded understanding of how Montessori methodologies are enacted in real-world settings. Furthermore, the researchers examined relevant governmental documents, including the Heritage-Based Curriculum Framework for Primary and Secondary Education 2024-2030, and the Ministry of Higher and Tertiary Education, Innovation and Technology Development's Heritage –Based Doctrine Education 5.0.



This analysis provided a broader context for understanding the educational curriculum in Zimbabwe and how it intersects with both heritage-based and Montessori methodologies. By reviewing these foundational documents, the researchers sought to identify the official educational policies and guidelines that shape the instructional practices in schools. This comprehensive approach to data collection, combining interviews, observations, and document analysis, facilitated a rich narrative that contributes to the growing discourse on inclusive education practices within Zimbabwe's diverse educational frameworks.



10.4 COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

This will be completed after data analysis that establishes the situation in Zimbabwe. Provisionally it appears that in Zimbabwe Montessori schools target the well-off members of the community. This makes Montessori education inaccessible to economically disadvantaged. This is the opposite of the situation in Kenya and Tanzania where Montessori institutions were established to benefit the economically disadvantaged. This could be because while in Kenya and Tanzania, Montessori schools were established by missionary institutions, in Zimbabwe Montessori schools were established by individuals who were not satisfied by the traditional system of education especially parents whose children could not fit into the traditional schools.

While in Kenya and Tanzania those who initiated the Montessori schools were trained Montessori Method practitioners, in Zimbabwe some of Montessori school owners had to learn about the Montessori Method after establishing their schools. In Zimbabwe Montessori schools are generally located in urban areas, while in Kenya and Tanzania they have a mix (urban and rural).



11.0 POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

- Mandatory training for teachers in Montessori
- All teachers to have exposure to Montessori methods of education as opposed to just knowing the theory without practice.



12.0 CONCLUSION

These discussion are tentative or provisional as the data analysis still has to be done. Data collection is still need to be polished up through engaging some of the interviewees who were not available during the researchers' visits. There is a lot of potential of synergy between Heritage Based Curriculum and the Montessori Method.



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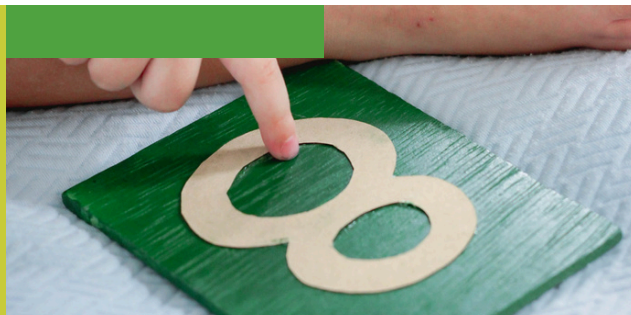
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THANK YOU

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